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INTERNATIONAL AUTUMN SALE, 19 NOVEMBER 2022





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LARASATI INTERNATIONAL AUTUMN SALE

LIVE STREAMING FROM

London • Singapore • Jakarta

AUCTION

Saturday, 19 November 2022

LIVE STREAMS starting from

10 am (London) | 6 pm (Singapore) | 5 pm (Jakarta)

SELECTED PREVIEW

Friday, 18 November 2022 (11 am - 7 pm)

at

THE HERMITAGE, A TRIBUTE PORTFOLIO HOTEL, JAKARTA

Menteng Room, Mezzanine Floor

Jl. Cilacap No. 1, Menteng

Jakarta, Indonesia

(Please call us if you need further assistance)

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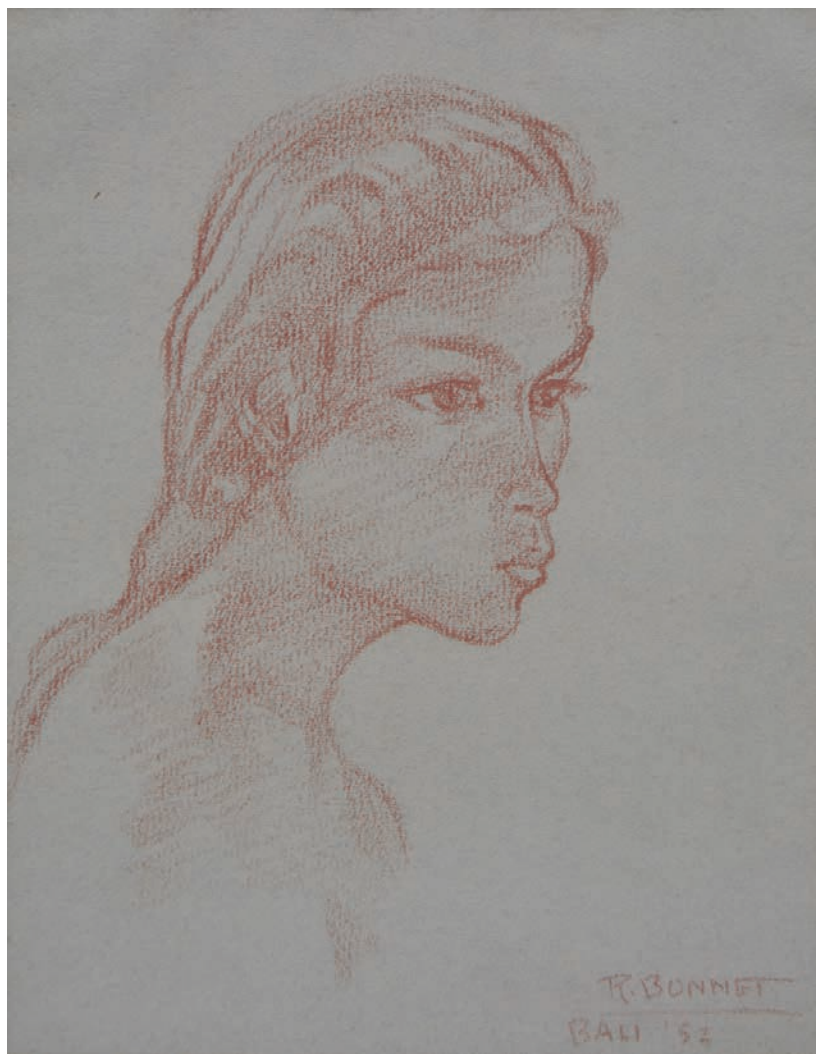
LARASATI INTERNATIONAL AUTUMN SALE

London • Singapore • Jakarta

LIVE BIDDING FROM
London, Singapore & Jakarta

19 November 2022 (Saturday)
Starting from
10 am (London) | 6 pm (Singapore) | 5 pm (Jakarta)

LOT 701 - 721



701

BONNET, RUDOLF

(1895 - 1978, Dutch)

Portrait of Ni Radji

executed in 1952; red chalk on paper; 22.5 x 17.5 cm
signed and dated on lower right

£ 500 - 800

S\$ 813 - 1,300

Pick up point: Jakarta



702

COVARRUBIAS, MIGUEL

(1904 - 1957, Mexican)

Head of a Balinese Girl

lithograph, ed. 30/50 B; 30 x 23 cm (image), 51 x 45 cm (paper)
numbered on lower left, signed on lower right

£ 800 - 1,200

S\$ 1,300 - 1,950

Pick up point: Jakarta



703

HOFKER, WILLEM GERARD

(1902 - 1981, Dutch)

Ni Kenjung Standing

etching; 30 x 24 cm
signed on lower right

£ 700 - 900

S\$ 1,140 - 1,465

Pick up point: Jakarta



704

TRUBUS SOEDARSONO

(1924 - 1966, Indonesian)

Balinese Beauty

oil on canvas; 79 x 60 cm
signed on lower left

£ 1,300 - 1,800

S\$ 2,113 - 2,925

Pick up point: Jakarta



705

SUDARSO

(1914 - 2006, Indonesian)

Legenda Jaka Tarub

Painted in 1965; oil on canvas glued on board; 36 x 52 cm
signed and dated on lower right

£ 600 - 800

S\$ 975 - 1,300

Pick up point: Jakarta



706

AGUS DJAJA

(1913 - 1994, Indonesian)

Jatayu Fighting Rahwana

Painted in 1974; oil on canvas; 169 x 99 cm
signed and dated on lower right

£ 1,300 - 1,800

S\$ 2,113 - 2,925

Pick up point: Jakarta



707

MURNIASIH, I GUSTI AYU KADEK

(1966 - 2006, Indonesian)

Asmara Millenium

Painted in 2000; acrylic on canvas; 150 x 150 cm (three panels)
inscribed and signed on the reverse

£ 4,500 - 5,500

S\$ 7,315 - 8,940

Pick up point: Jakarta



708

HENING PURNAMAWATI

(1960 - 2017, Indonesian)

Menggapai Ozon

painted in 1997; oil on canvas; 90 x 70 cm
 signed and dated on lower right
 signed and inscribed on the reverse

£ 550 - 750

S\$ 894 - 1,219

Pick up point: Jakarta



709

NASHAR

(1928 - 1994, Indonesian)

Abstract Composition

Painted in 1984; oil on canvas; 65.5 x 98 cm
Signed with the artist's monogram and dated on lower right

£ 2,300 - 2,800

S\$ 3,740 - 4,550

Pick up point: Jakarta



710

EMIRIA SOENASSA

(1894/1895 - 1964, Indonesian)

Kembang Sederhana

painted in 1958; oil on canvas; 65.5 x 46.5

signed and dated on lower left; inscribed and signed on the reverse

£ 3,400 - 4,400

S\$ 5,525 - 7,150

Proveance: From the collection of Mochtar Apin's Family, Indonesia

Pick up point: Jakarta



711

SADALI, AHMAD

(1924 - 1987, Indonesian)

**Bidang Keriput Dasar Hitam dan Emas
(Creased Space, Black Base and Gold)**

painted in 1972; mixed media on canvas; 80 x 65 cm
signed and dated on lower left

£ 30,000 - 40,000

S\$ 48,750 - 65,000

Provenance:

Acquired from the family of the artist; Private Asian Collection

Literature:

Jim Supangkat, *The Hidden Works of Ahmad Sadali*, Edwin's Gallery & Coutts Bank, Jakarta, 1997. Illustrated in colour, p. 24

Exhibition:

"The Hidden Works and Thoughts of Ahmad Sadali", by Edwin Galeri, Jakarta, October 17- 26, 1997. Illustrated page 29 of the catalogue.

Pick up point: Jakarta

Bidang Keriput Dasar Hitam dan Emas (Creased Space, Black Base and Gold)

This mixed media work from the mature period of Ahmad Sadali's career is significant for the fact that it encapsulates a specific period in modern Indonesian art history. Sadali was a key figure amongst the first generation of graduates from the Bandung School, which is historically associated with Western schools of art, but he was also a primary figure in the promotion the Islamic identity through abstraction. In this position he spanned the gulf between an Indonesian identity and international artistic discourse.

Sadali himself likened the act of painting as a spiritual process.¹ In *Creased Space, Black Base and Gold*, he constructs a geometric field in the central panel consists of a square divided into four triangles, with the upper and lower ones split vertically from pinnacle to mid-base. The triangle can be read as a mountain, which has particular relevance to Islam through the foundational story of the Prophet Muhammad receiving the first revelations of the Holy Quran at Mount Hira. The triangle is a motif Sadali uses regularly to represent a mountain in his work, as seen in a painting from the same period as the present work: *Gunungan, the Beginning & the End* (1971).² The triangle might also be interpreted as the shape of vernacular mosque architecture in Indonesia,³ a connection that would be consistent with Sadali's profound personal beliefs: he led the establishment of the Islamic University of Bandung and served as chairman of the ITB Salman Mosque Development. The triangle as a geometric shape is also associated with consciousness through the representation of the knower, the known and the act of knowing.⁴ Likewise, the square within which the triangles fit can be read as the four elements of earth, wind, fire and air, while the circles – having no beginning nor end – represent wholeness, unity and protection.⁵

Other formal qualities embed this work into a specific period of Sadali's career. In the early 1970s he adopted dark, earthy tones and a visceral approach to materials that emphasised tactile surface. In addition, in *Creased Space* the canvas support also becomes medium through its three-dimensionality, morphing into textile sculpture. A comparable work of similar date, *Lelehan Emas pada Bidang Keriput* (1973) has precisely the same qualities.⁶ These characteristics set Sadali's practice clearly within international tropes of the period where the divide between medium and support is broken down. More broadly, it can be contextualised within the media theory of the philosopher Marshall McLuhan (1911-1980), who argued that the medium is the message in his seminal *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (1964).⁷ In Sadali's case, if the medium is the message, then the material is the spiritual.

The Bandung School

Art historically, Sadali is representative of the specific training accessible to Indonesian artists at in the Post-war period at either Bandung or Yogyakarta. He trained initially in the early 1950s under Dutch painter Ries Mulder (1909-1973), who built up the Fine Art Department at what is now known as ITB, the Bandung Institute of Technology.⁸ Along the way a strong cohort of undergraduates that included Sadali and Srihadi

¹ Art Agenda SEA: <https://www.artagendasea.org/artists/ahmad-sadali>. Accessed 31.10.22.

² Sold at Sotheby's Hong Kong, 7 October 2012, for HKD680,000 (USD87,720) hammer.

³ J. Jamaludin, 'Understanding the Meaning of Triangular Shape in Mosque Architecture in Indonesia', *International Journal of Engineering and Technology*, 7 (4.7) (2018) 458-462. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/331104278_Understanding_the_Meaning_of_Triangular_Shape_in_Mosque_Architecture_in_Indonesia. Accessed 1.11.22.

⁴ https://www.mhs.ox.ac.uk/scienceislam_education/docs/Geometric%20drawing%20in%20Islam.pdf. Accessed 1.11.22.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Sold at Larasati on 12 December 2019 for IDR 380m (USD 27,170) hammer. It was resold at Sotheby's Hong Kong, 28 April 2022, for HKD 320,000 (USD40,780).

⁷ Originally published New York: Mentor, 1964. Frank Gillette argues that McLuhan's theory embodies attitudes in the 1960s that can applied to everything from the formalism of Clement Greenberg to discourses on Pop Art. See McLuhan & Art History: Take One / Oral Version, March 1998 / NYC / Delivered at Fordam's University's Conference on McLuhan. <https://www.frankgillette.com/mcluhan-art-history>. Accessed 31.10.22.

⁸ While the institution was founded in 1920, the training of artists only began in 1947 when the Drawing School opened in the Faculty of Engineering. Mulder drove the expansion of the art teaching from the training of art teachers to a functioning academy, which resulted in a Fine Art department in 1956.



Soedarsono (see lot 720) were learning how to experiment with materials and techniques. Mulder himself worked in a Cubist-inflected style based on the work of French painter Jacques Villon (1875-1963), one of the Salon Cubists in pre-war Paris.⁹ This was picked up by many of his students during their early years, including Sadali, and is the reason for the long-held (and now largely irrelevant) opinion that Bandung framed its identity around Western art discourses. However, most graduates of Bandung moved away from this form of practice as they pursued postgraduate studies abroad, which not only opened up new discourses but also enabled them to look at Indonesian identity with the clarity of distance.¹⁰ Mulder himself argued against the notion that Bandung forced the Western mindset on the students, saying that he aimed to make them develop independence of mind that would enable them to move away from his influence and find their own paths.¹¹ Sadali is a case in point: having graduated in 1953, he immediately joined the teaching staff before leaving for the US for postgraduate study at the State University, Iowa, on a Rockefeller grant in 1956-57. He joined the freewheeling community of the Art Students League of New York in 1957 and by 1963 had abandoned any semblance of the Cubist style into the more biomorphic forms of pure abstraction. He moved away from light colours of the late 1950s to the more intense hues in impasto brushstrokes during the 1960s; by the early 1970s, he had turned towards the dark earth tones with which *Creased Space* was executed before his palate lightened again in the last decade of his life.

Viv Lawes

Consultant Lecturer, Sotheby's Institute of Art
Course Leader, University of the Arts London
Senior Lecturer, City & Guilds of London Art School

⁹ Claire Holt, *Art in Indonesia: Continuities and Change*. Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1967.

¹⁰ Ibid. p.238

¹¹ Ibid. p.236



712

FADJAR SIDDIK

(1930 - 2004, Indonesian)

Komposisi Pada Bidang Biru

Painted in 2003; oil on canvas; 100 x 80 cm
signed and dated on lower right

£ 2,800 - 3,800

S\$ 4,550 - 6,175

Pick up point: Jakarta



713

FADJAR SIDDIK

(1930 - 2004, Indonesian)

Komposisi Pada Bidang Coklat

Painted in 2001; oil on canvas; 90 x 70 cm
signed and dated on lower right

£ 2,000 - 3,000

S\$ 3,250 - 4,875

Pick up point: Jakarta



714

WIDAYAT

(1919/1923 - 2002, Indonesian)

Ikan-ikan

Painted in 1990; oil on canvas laid on board; 27 x 34 cm

signed and dated on lower left

inscribed, signed and dated on the reverse

£ 800 - 1,100

S\$ 1,300 - 1,788

Pick up point: Jakarta



715

POPO ISKANDAR

(1927 - 2000, Indonesian)

Black Cat

Painted in 1991; oil on canvas laid on board; 65 x 60 cm
signed and dated on upper left

£ 2,200 - 3,200

S\$ 3,575 - 5,200

Pick up point: Jakarta



716

POPO ISKANDAR
(1927 - 2000, Indonesian)

Flying Bird

Painted in 1986; oil on canvas; 97 x 83 cm
Signed and dated on lower left

£ 4,000 - 5,000
S\$ 6,500 - 8,125

Pick up point: Jakarta

717

KERTON, SUDJANA

(1922 - 1994, Indonesian)

a. Portrait

gouache on paper; 31 x 27 cm
signed on lower right

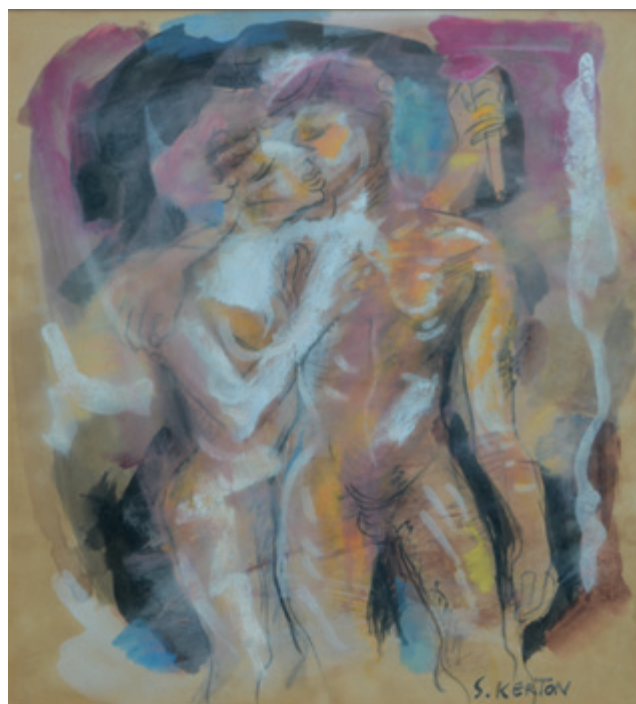
b. Love Affair

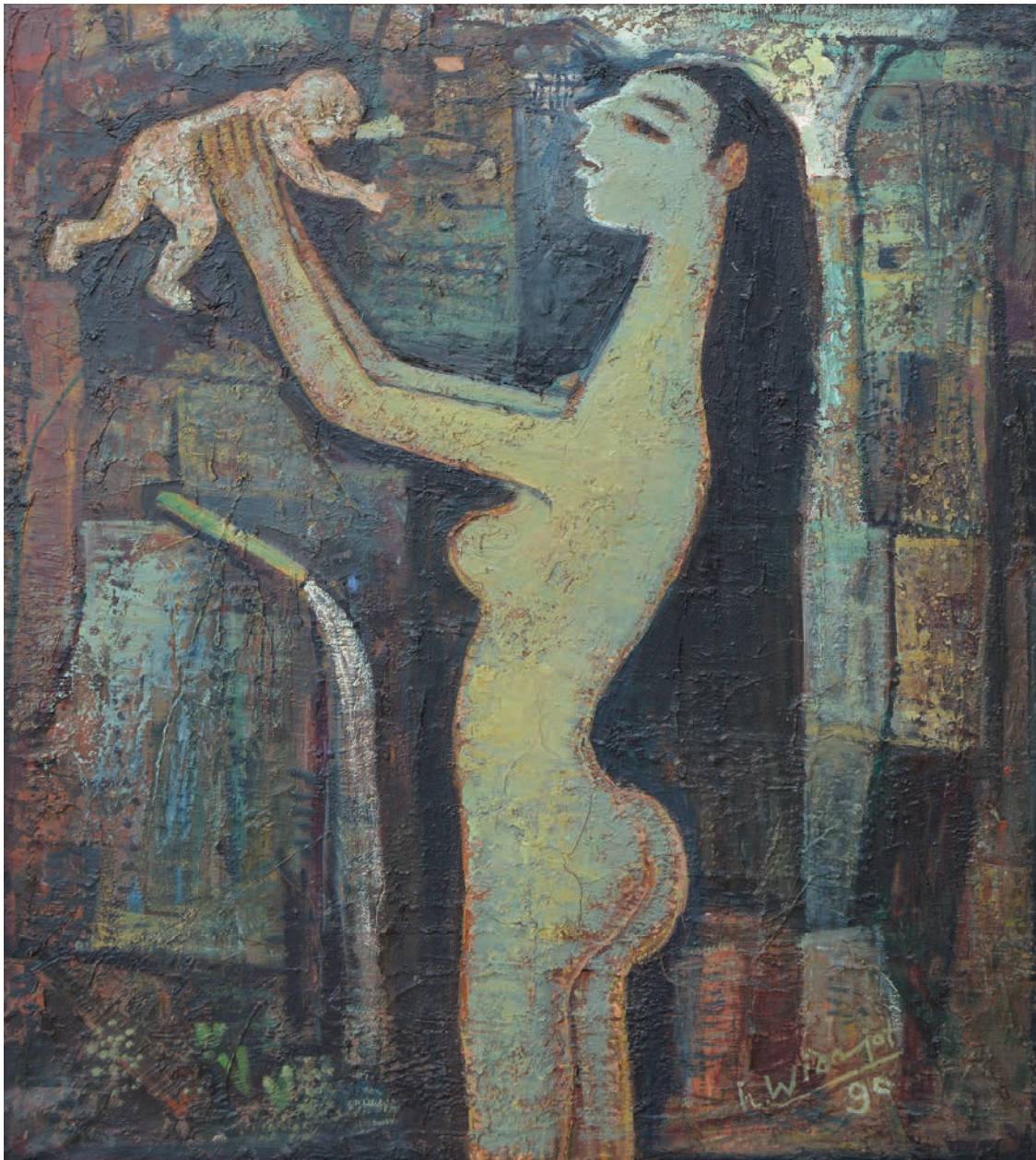
pastel on paper; 30 x 27 cm
signed on lower right

£ 650 - 850

S\$ 1,057 - 1,381

Pick up point: Jakarta





718

WIDAYAT

(1919/1923 - 2002, Indonesian)

Anakku Sayang

Painted in 1990; oil on canvas; 60 x 70 cm

signed and dated on lower right

inscribed, signed and dated on the reverse

£ 1,300 - 1,800

S\$ 2,113 - 2,925

Pick up point: Jakarta



719

JEIHAN

(1938 - 2019, Indonesian)

Inan

Painted in 1992; oil on canvas; 140 x 90 cm
signed and dated on lower left; inscribed and signed on the reverse

£ 2,200 - 3,200

S\$ 3,575 - 5,200

Pick up point: Jakarta



720

SRIHADI SOEDARSONO

(1931 - 2022, Indonesian)

Tiga Penari (Three Dancers)

Painted in 1965; oil on canvas; 140 x 108 cm
signed and dated on upper right

£ 36,000 - 46,000

S\$ 58,500 - 74,750

Literature:

Jean Couteau, *Srihadi Soedarsoon: The Path of the Soul*,
The Lontar Foundation, Jakarta, Indonesia, p. 164-165,
full page colour illustration

Jim Supangkat, *"Indonesian Modern Art and Beyond"*,
Yayasan Seni Rupa Indonesia, Indonesia, 1996.
Illustrated in colour, p. 63

Pick up point: Jakarta

Three Dancers

Three Dancers is an early work by Indonesian modernist Srihadi in a genre that is arguably the most instantly recognisable of those to which he returned repeatedly: traditional Javanese or Balinese dancers, shown singly or in groups performing pre-colonial court dances. It is rarer than the later works on the same theme, which are more rhythmic and faster than this still, contemplative, psychologically intense work.

It was painted seven years after Srihadi had finished his training at ITB, the Bandung Institute of Technology, studying, like Ahmad Sadali (see Lot 711), under Ries Mulder (1909-1973). By the time he painted this in 1965 he had moved on from the Cubist technique of his undergraduate years and had come into close contact with Abstract Expressionism through his postgraduate degree at Ohio State University. The brushy impasto stroke for which he is best known later in his career is visible but restrained here; more striking is the connection with the puppets and masks seen in his work as a new graduate, such as *Topeng-Topeng (Masks)*, 1960.¹ Srihadi was fascinated not only by traditional dance but also by other arts to which he had been introduced by his grandfather, like *wayang* theatre, *batik* and *keris* metalsmithing.² His identity as an Indonesian artist shines through his choice of motif, while his technique and style is embedded in international discourses of the time.

Several characteristics in *Three Dancers* are comparable to other dancer paintings of the mid-sixties, which can be seen by comparing it to the identically-titled *Three Dancers*, painted in 1966 (sold Sotheby's Hong Kong, 1 April 2019 for HKD 320,000/ USD40,760 hammer). The dancers' lower bodies appear to dissolve into the dark ground layer; the features of faces and hands are articulated through the scratched-out oil paint; the white masks, or possibly white make-up, obscure the individual character of their faces; even the three positions of their faces in opposing three-quarter views and profile are shared between the two versions. The costumes are similar to the green dress and gold tabard often worn to perform the Balinese dance Condong Legong, which tells the story of two princesses and their maidservant. In this *Three Dancers* closely resembles *Dancer in Green*, a single-figure dancer painting also executed in 1966, which came onto the market in 2014.³

Throughout his long career Srihadi pursued figuration and landscape rather than abstraction. He always sought out singularly Indonesian subject matter, returning repeatedly to traditional dancers, views of Borobudur or Mount Merapi. It is striking that whether the subject matter is figurative or landscape, all of his works have a strong sense of depersonalisation. His dancers do not have individual characters; instead they are grouped together as a cultural construction of pre-colonial Indonesia. He uses the device of the repeated motif, whether elaborately costumed dancers or a serenely looming Borobudur, like a mantra through which he beats out the rhythm of his meditation on the nature of identity.

Viv Lawes

Consultant Lecturer, Sotheby's Institute of Art
Course Leader, University of the Arts London
Senior Lecturer, City & Guilds

¹ Sold at 33 Auction PTE, 7 June 2020 for SGD 48,000/ USD34,460 hammer.

² Art Agenda SEA: <https://www.artagendasea.org/artists/srihadi-soedarsono>. Accessed 1.11.22.

³ Sold at Christie's Hong Kong, 14 November 2014, for HKD700,000/ USD90,230 hammer.





三
岁
1980



Rice Pounding

Cheong Soo Pieng's *Rice Pounding*, 1980, is a magisterial composition of magical realism.¹ It is on the market for the first time exactly 39 years after it was first publicly exhibited at his retrospective at the National Museum Art Gallery, Singapore (11-23 November 1983), which was one of the 'Pioneer Artists of Singapore' series inaugurated in 1981 to celebrate the Nanyang School. Soo Pieng was a foundational member of the Nanyang style and philosophy, "one of the first to set the pace in evolving an art form distinctive to this region"², which conflated Chinese ink painting with Western modernism, imbued with the spirit of the 'Southern Seas'.

Rice Pounding engages the senses beyond vision. You can almost hear the rhythmic thumping of pestle on mortar, even as seven Balinese women hold their long wooden pestles upright during a momentary break in their labour, splitting the pictorial space vertically in an insistent beat: one-three-two-one from left to right, like crotchets on a musical stave. While they wait in suspended animation, other women sieve the rice to remove the powdered husks, or pour it and press it into storage baskets, working together in a gendered community activity that they would have learned as children. The painting captures this traditional daily ritual that structures the agricultural cycle of rural life in Bali, which Soo Pieng may have observed at first hand during the seminal trip he made to the island with fellow Nanyang artists Chen Wen Hsi, Liu Kang and Chen Chong Swee in 1952. More trips to Bali followed, with several taking place in the 1960s, and Soo Pieng made an undated preparatory ink sketch (see above) that forms the basis of the present painting.³



Untitled, Chinese ink
Photo courtesy of family of artist.

As usual with Soo Pieng, a sense of dreamlike fantasy pervades depictions of normality. De-husking rice grains manually would have been a common sight at the time this painting was executed; now, forty years after his death, it still survives but is perhaps increasingly an act of resistance to changing rhythms of life. Historic photographs of Balinese women pounding rice reveals how true to life this painting really is, right down to the division of labour that saw women working in groups, wearing cloth wrapped around their heads and often bare-breasted in the heat. They are shown dressed in the same ikat woven or batik dyed *kamben* in shades of red, orange, brown and ochre, sometimes green, leavened with indigo, although Soo Pieng conflated the traditional textiles of Bali that he loved by depicting both everyday batik designs and the complex double ikat woven *geringsing* ceremonial textiles that are a speciality of the indigenous Balinese in the eastern village of Tenganan Pegeringsingan.

Stylistically, *Rice Pounding* is characteristic of the work Soo Pieng predominantly produced from the mid-1970s until his death in 1983. The figuration reveals hybrid sources in the emaciated outlines of Chinese *gongbi* painting, slender bodies, large heads and stick limbs familiar from the *wayang kulit* puppets of the Malay archipelago, with the facial features of Dayak wooden dolls living through the large, dark almond-shaped eyes. In many of the works of this late period one sees elements of 20th century Ubud-style painting from Bali, but here the Balinese elements are manifest in the dotted brushstrokes in the background and middle ground, which are reminiscent of the air symbol in classical Kamasan paintings. They also recall the *cun* (texture strokes) of Chinese ink painting, which Soo Pieng frequently included in these works to add texture without creating a solid background. The same technique can be found in the foreground treatment of *Resting*, 1977 (sold Larasati, 27 Jan 2022, SGD610,000/ USD450,000 including premium) and the middle ground of *Satay Seller*, 1982 (sold Larasati, 26 March 2022, SGD 1,061,400/ USD 780,000 including premium).

¹ When exhibited in the *Pioneer Artists of Singapore* series at the National Museum Art Gallery, Singapore, 11-23 November 1983, this painting was given the title *Ploughing*. The material was listed as "oil" but subsequent analysis has revealed that the canvas was overlaid with support media (paper) to primarily create a smooth surface across the seam. The publication *Soo Pieng*, Singapore: Summer Times Publishing, 1983, titles the painting *Rice Pounding* (Plate 26).

² As described at the official opening of the retrospective in a speech by Health and Culture Secretary Wan Hussin Zoohri. Singapore Government Press Release 04-3/83/11/10, 25 Nov 1983. <https://www.nas.gov.sg/archivesonline/data/pdfdoc/ewhz19831110s.pdf>; accessed 22.10.22.

³ Soo Pieng's ink sketch is included in the book titled "*Cheong Soo Pieng, Visions of Southeast Asia*", which was published in conjunction with the exhibition "*Cheong Soo Pieng: Bridging Worlds*" at The National Gallery, Singapore in 2010. The collections held by the National Museum of Singapore also include a sketch depicting rice pounding by Chen Chong Swee (1910-1985), 1971, Chinese ink and colour on paper, 242 x 117cm. See Kwok Kian Chow, *Channels & Confluences: A History of Singapore Art*. Singapore: National Heritage Board/Singapore Art Museum, 1996. Plate 64. Online image: https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/pounding-rice-chen-chong-swee/bwHmi82_CXhPIQ. Accessed 25.10.22.



721

CHEONG SOO PIENG

(1917 - 1983, Singaporean)

Rice Pounding

Painted in 1980; oil on canvas stabilised with support media; 101 x 119 cm
signed in Chinese and dated on lower left; signed in English and dated on the back of the canvas

£ 340,000 - 400,000

S\$ 550,000 - 650,000

This lot is accompanied with Certificate of Authenticity by Mr. Cheong Wai Chi, son of the artist.

Literature:

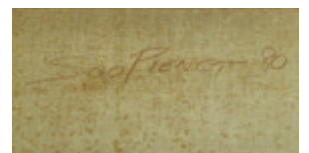
- National Museum Art Gallery, Singapore, *Cheong Soo Pieng Retrospective* 1983, 'Pioneer Artist of Singapore', Singapore 11-27 November 1983, The Ministry of Culture, Singapore. Illustrated in exhibition catalogue and titled, "Ploughing".

- *SOO PIENG*, Summer Times Publishing, 1983, illustrated in colour, plate 26 and titled, "Rice Pounding (1980) oil".

Exhibition:

Cheong Soo Pieng 1983 Retrospective, "Pioneer Artists of Singapore," Singapore, 11-17 November 1983, National Museum Art Gallery, Singapore.

Pick up Point: Singapore



The composition of this work is more classical, in the Western art historical sense, than some of Soo Pieng's works in this idiom. The woman in the centre sieving the rice creates the vanishing point as well as the apex of a compositional pyramid, the negative space of the glimmering gold ground below which completes the structure. This is extended by the woman to the extreme left bending over her basket and to the right by the woman pouring rice from her sieve to her basket. The painting is also unusual for the greater sense of depth created through the recession of the baskets in the right foreground. They spill off beyond the lower right corner to define the illusionistic three-dimensional space by creating a wedge-shaped passage that recedes in single point perspective to the vanishing point. It lends a dynamism to the composition that butts against the denial of recessive space created by the dotted brushstrokes of the background and illuminated golden surface. This suffusion of gold also creates a sense of the magical. It is known through interviews with Soo Pieng's family that he experimented with gold, silver and bronze acrylic paint for the backgrounds, which dried quickly, and then painted over it with oil glazes tinted with raw umber to lend depth and translucency.⁴

As well as pushing his use of medium, he also experimented with supports.⁵ In *Rice Pounding* we see that the canvas is joined horizontally across the bottom third of the painting, with sparse grass heads sprouting through the earth following the line of the seam. However, he applied a layer of paper over the canvas in order to create as smooth a surface as possible across the seam. This additional top layer over the canvas would absorb more oil paint into the surface, increasing density and saturation. This method recalls the techniques of Russian-French modernist Marc Chagall (1887-1985), whose *Song of Songs* series (1957-1966) in the Marc Chagall National Museum, Nice, reveal exactly the same combination of support materials.

Soo Pieng's willingness, or rather urge, to experiment continually is arguably a result of his peripatetic life during his formative years. His identity as a Chinese émigré artist who trained in Chinese art schools in the pre-war years – in his case the Xiamen Academy of Fine Arts in Amoy and the Xin Hua Academy in Shanghai – places him in that particular time and space in the history of Singaporean art when barriers were breaking down in both the Chinese and Western traditions. He fits the writer Malcolm Gladwell's model of an "Outlier": a person who is situated differently from the mainstream.⁶ Applying this model to the art world, one can propose that Soo Pieng does not fit precisely into either the Chinese or Western artistic tradition, but that this outlying position gave him the opportunity to train in new ways as a result of when and where he was born. He studied in the Chinese art academies that had introduced Western materials and techniques into the curriculum alongside traditional Chinese ink painting in the early 20th century. This does not mean his life was easy; he had to drive his own success. What it means is that he took advantage of a situation that was unstable – namely, life in China in 1945 – and used it to propel himself into a more promising environment by settling in Singapore the following year after a short stint in Hong Kong, Taiwan and Macau.⁷ Last but not least, he fulfils Gladwell's "10,000-hour rule": he put in the necessary labour by working every day in his studio in order to become an expert. His practice – varied, constantly evolving but always recognisable – is testament to the dedication necessary to achieve a lasting place in Singapore and, increasingly, international art history.

Viv Lawes

Consultant Lecturer, Sotheby's Institute of Art
Course Leader, University of the Arts London
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⁴ Interview with Soo Pieng's daughter, Ms. Cheong: Mar Gomez Lobon, *A Life of Experimentation: An insight into Cheong Soo Pieng's painting materials and techniques*, 2010, p.10. Download at: <https://docplayer.net/36102353-A-life-of-experimentation-an-insight-into-cheong-soo-pieng-s-painting-materials-and-techniques.html> p.11.

⁵ Ibid., p.10.

⁶ Malcolm Gladwell, *Outliers: The Story of Success*. London: Penguin Books, 2009.

⁷ Art Commune Gallery Cheong Soo Pieng Timeline. <https://www.cheongsopie.com/timeline>: accessed 24.10.22.



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